

Notre-Dame Cathedral

France's famous medieval Gothic cathedral, renowned for its rose windows and grotesque statues popularized by Victor Hugo



Standing on the eastern end of the Île de la Cité in Paris, Notre-Dame Cathedral was begun by Maurice de Sully, bishop of Paris, in 1163. A succession of four master builders worked to complete the choir, western facade, and nave by 1250; more chapels were added over the following century.

A Gothic masterpiece

The cathedral's two massive three-story towers, single-arch flying buttresses, and three large rose windows make it characteristically Gothic (see pp.126–127). However, it was set apart from contemporary church buildings by the naturalism and scale of its sculptures. Its three huge portals were decorated with vividly carved

Biblical scenes, as well as symbols of medieval science and philosophy; these created a *liber pauperum* ("poor people's book") through which Biblical stories could be understood even by the illiterate. The cathedral's exterior was also decorated with extraordinary carved grotesques, fantastical monsters that served either to ward off evil or channel rainwater. They also provided inspiration for Victor Hugo's novel *The Hunchback of Notre-Dame* in 1831. The cathedral was desecrated during the French Revolution of 1789, but Hugo's novel revived interest in the building, and in 1845, French architect Eugène Viollet-le-Duc began restoring it. In April 2019, the spire and most of the roof were destroyed by fire, although the cathedral's main stone structure remained standing.

The **largest** of the cathedral's **10 bells** is known as **Emmanuel** and weighs **14 tons (13 tonnes)**



◁ SPIRE AND SAINTS

Twelve copper statues of the Apostles surround the 19th-century, lead-covered oak spire, which was destroyed in the 2019 fire.

△ HOLY ISLAND

This view of Notre-Dame and the Île de la Cité from the east shows the large flying buttresses around the apse and the south transept's rose window.

GOTHIC FACADE

Notre-Dame's Gothic west facade spans 134 ft (41m). It incorporates three portals—the largest is the Portal of the Last Judgment—and a 31-ft- (9.6-m-) wide rose window. The verticality of the high towers is balanced by horizontal galleries to create an elegant but powerful elevation.

